

ANI

UNDER OPPOSITION ATTACK Chief election commissioner Gyanesh Kumar (centre) with election commissioner Dr Sukhbir Singh Sandhu (left) and Dr Vivek Joshi at Nirvachan Sadan, New Delhi

THE CHARGE In Bihar's Special Intensive Revision (SIR), the Opposition accuses the ECI of restricting voter enrolment by excluding Aadhaar from the list of accepted documents, claiming most residents lacked other papers

ECI'S RESPONSE: Aadhaar cannot prove citizenship

TRUST SAFEGUARD: The Supreme Court has upheld the ECI's stand and rejected the claim that most residents lacked required documents

THE CHARGE After revealing the deletion of 6.5 million names from Bihar's rolls, those challenging SIR sought the names and reasons for each exclusion

ECI'S RESPONSE: No legal obligation to publish deletion lists or give individual explanations

TRUST SAFEGUARD: Following an SC directive, the ECI has agreed to publish the list of deleted names along with the reasons for deletion

advertisements in newspapers, radio and TV. These will also be posted on notice boards at the offices of booth level officers (BLO), panchayats and block development offices.

CRISIS OF CONFIDENCE

On paper, the ECI's safeguards appear robust: no deletion without prior notice, a hearing, and a written order, with the option to appeal up to the chief electoral officer. In practice, critics question how such procedures can be meaningfully applied to millions of cases within a compressed timeline. The SC has so far declined to halt Bihar's SIR, only cautioned the ECI against "mass exclusion". Justice Surya Kant described the controversy as "largely a case of trust deficit", urging the ECI to substantiate its assurances with transparent data, a request that, so far, has met only with bureaucratic stonewalling.

On the issue of transparency, the ECI has offered no clear answers, even as reports surfaced of seasonal migrant workers being wrongly marked as permanently relocated. On August 12, Yadav even walked in for a SC hearing with two 'dead voters' to prove his point of methodological anarchy. Senior advocate Rakesh Dwivedi, for the ECI, said such minor errors are typical of a draft roll and can be fixed by BLOs. Justice Surya Kant agreed, noting that inadvertent mistakes are inevitable but correctable.

The ECI's standing as an impartial constitutional authority is doubtless under strain. In an era of instant digital sharing, it has been notably frugal, old-fashioned and bureaucratic about data. When the Congress requested machine-readable copies of Maharashtra's voter lists to conduct its own analysis, the ECI refused, saying the party already had them in physical form. Rawat opposes making electoral rolls publicly available in digital form, calling it a sensitive database highly susceptible to manipulation. However, he maintains that the ECI must take every possible step to strengthen public trust in democratic processes, including conducting a thorough probe into Rahul's allegations.

For now, Rahul's "vote *chori*" allegations and Bihar's SIR remain separate sagas, one a sweeping political charge, the other a procedural tsunami in a single state. But they converge on the same fault line: whether India's electoral rolls, the bedrock of its democracy, can still command public trust. Once that trust erodes, it will matter little whether deletions were lawful or proofs sound. What will matter is that millions may believe the list itself is rigged. ■